Flying

By Carol K. Mack

OK, here's the hard part. . . OK, a couple of months ago? When I was human, that's when it all started. Right in front of the student center on February 10th at three o'clock. The bells on the campus chapel were going off, which is how I know the time. Anyhow, I was just standing there when I saw this feather. It was lying on the snow? (She reaches down, picks it up, examines it.) It was white as the snow so it was nearly invisible. And it had these. . . markings. This weird blue design on the underside, almost like a code, and it . . . well, it smelled so familiar, and that's when it hit me. This was all a message. And for the first time in my life, everything fell into place. I realized. . . I knew that my real father was a bird. (Shifts uncomfortably, lifting her elbows, shoulders.)

INTRODUCTION

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During the following relived memory, Kay, 19, very bright, vulnerable, quirky, transforms from human to bird. She may be speaking to us in her Post-Avian state from a place on the lawn of her school or home or hospital. Wherever she is, she is alone and she wants us to understand her story. The birdlike mannerisms that express themselves throughout the story and that finally overwhelm her are to be invented by the actress.

So then what? I mean I knew I'd have to confront my mom with this. But she'd never admit it. She hates talking about what she calls "closed chapters" of her life? That includes a lotta stuff; I mean was it a one-night stand? And how could

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she forget? My mom is so . . . How could I ask her about transpecies lovers? And there are other questions. DNA-related ones. Like, could I fly? I mean at that point I still didn't know. (Moves around, slightly more avian, annoyed at the memory.)

The day before the feather, I had, coincidentally, picked my freshman term-paper topic from this list of choices and of course I picked Quetzalcoatl. I always had this, connection, to Quetzalcoatl, y'know, that gorgeous Aztec plumed serpent god. But this witch, Ashley Williams? She claimed her great-great-grandmother was one-eighth Guatemalan, and she picked Quetzalcoatl too. So the professor told me that since the Aztecs were really more Ashley's than mine, why didn't I think about Druids or something!? I said to Tim, "It's not fair." "Life's not fair, mate," Tim said. He used to call my roommate "mate," too, when they were dating. So I never know-is it 'cause he gets us mixed up or 'cause he's from Australia? Everybody's from somewhere but me . . . (She crosses her arms, flaps her elbows.) Bummer.

Before the feather it was such a totally awful year. My roommate freaked out and dropped out and then I moved in with her ex, Tim. He has this gorgeously unpronounceable name and is so . . . intense, and he's also very cute. All I wanted was a name like his, with two clinking consonants at the top that linked me to some exotic ancient land. Something mysterious to sign my papers with. A name with maybe only clicks. A name that if you said it the wrong way would mean something like fart. But being from Long Island, well, like Tim says, that's Kansas. It's all Kansas, mate. (Growing indignant and "ruffled")

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So, anyhow, it was this very next day that my dad sent me his message by feather, and it wasn't long before "Kay Smith," in what looks like an ordinary human body, is utterly transformed. I began to hover, mentally at first. And in the library, I began hunting for my roots, my own folk culture, back to the first soaring Archaeopteryx! (Fascinated, enthusiastic) My dad's ancestral superiority is pretty evident! He had visual acuity way beyond human. And what about those impossible migratory navigational feats with no maps at all! Probably the most important find is this organ called the amygdala. It's this perfect snug core coiled way deep inside every single human brain. What does it do? It gives you this adrenal rush the minute an identifiable Other comes into view. (Triumphantly) And it's mine. It's MINE. I've got the original! It's premammal! It's this amygdala that's like the most important thing on campus! This amazing organ is more part of my heritage than my classmates' and never given credit! Ignored! But this very amygdala practically rules the roost and not just for sex, but even for (looking around) who you sit with in the cafeteria! Me? (Perches, rolling her shoulders) I sit by myself! And I begin to think a lot about flying.

(Romantically) Now that I'm no longer "Kay," who am I? I mean my real name must be so ancient a sound it couldn't even be represented by glyph! It's indecipherable, just a wingbrush, maybe a feathery noise like a breeze or a whisper. I wore my beautiful white feather at all times under my T-shirt, folded in my bra, near my heart. Hidden. (Annoyed) Of course I avoided wearing it in any fashion that I realized was just plain plumage display. Somebody might think it was some kind of Native American rip-off. It's not! And it's not Kabbalah, either! It's a Bird Thing!

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OK? Anyhow, as an Avian creature I am Beyond Culture. And also am totally beyond guilt for ever being anywhere where anybody was oppressed anytime in history' cause my dad's folks' folks were originally connected to the Great Auk. And the Great Auk lived on all these uninhabited isles and developed a near mythic reputation. But, well, that's only a guess. Dad may have been a swan.

To attempt to be true to my heritage I started to eat only trail mix. Tim said, "Losing weight, mate?" And I thought, what a jerk! What a jerk. Bird weight gain and loss is all timing. It's all about Nesting and Migration-why bother, he'd never understand. I just blinked at him. Then I realized I hadn't blinked in a week! You know what that means. Also I noticed this feeling of tension in my shoulder blades. I didn't know if it was stress and my knapsack or some latent sprouting at the base of my blades.

And I was just blown away by thinking about my amazing dad-I mean when I think about his air sacs, his fused hips, his great scaly feet: a faster heartbeat, air in his bones, and at least three times as many vertebrae in his neck! All these Avian traits filled me with such pride I could hardly keep from crowing. And to think that humans denigrate these glorious creatures with names like "secretary bird" and "grebes"!? And how about "crazy as a loon"? Or that really odious comparison of vultures to lawyers! (angry determination) I'll redress this. Yes. Why, we're everybody's icon: the eagle, the falcon, the dove! There's no ceiling on bird power. And where does Nietzsche come off using the eagle as if he had some inside track? You wish, Nietzsche! And Edgar Allen Poe. Nevermore!

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My paper's due, and I decide to present my own topic. Iit's gonna be all about bird sound and finally show how to talk to a bird. I know now. I can caw and warble. In bed I make new burry noises in my throat that scare Tim!

It was during finals, I "fixed on" the crowd sitting in their little tribal formations in the cafeteria. I decided right then to eliminate my memories and thus gain the necessary lightness for a demonstration. (Getting up on a bench, excitedly) I concentrated on my hidden feather, visualizing it a thousand fold, and when all I could see were white feathers with faint blue markings, I imagined myself covered with them, and I climbed onto my corner table and I rose up into the air! (arms spread in awe)

It was in this final soaring flight to the cafeteria ceiling, a burst of energy and weightlessness, that I first became aware of this sound under me. (Still, awe) The sounds rise unlike anything else in the universe! Each voice utterly unique, each vibration like no other in all time. And yes, YES, greater than any birdsong! It is this chorus of human voices that forms the up-current on which I glide. By human hum I hover, and I look down at all those eyes looking back at me! Those eyes. They're all filled with expression and each pair unlike any other pair, without the Avian brilliance or opaqueness-why they're filled with wonder at my flight! (Blinks away the humanity.)

OH! I try a new bird squint, first raising my powerful lower eyelid halfway up, then sliding the nictitating membrane, my third eyelid, horizontally across. I discover the use of this membrane which has eluded human ornithologists: what it does is

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filter the field of vision. OH! Now I can see all those amazing eyes with birdsight! They're like a shimmering lake, a continuum of light facets! OH! How incredible! (In a very different tone) That was my last conscious thought before I fell down near the hot trays. . . . (Moves to another place)

When I wake up, Tim's kneeling next to the doctor, looking worried. I try to speak, my beak. . . can't get my beak around the words. Nobody can hear me. Tim shrugs and he's swinging his ponytail, saying, "I dunno, mate. Magical realism?"

And then I look around and they're all looking so, helpless, so . . . sad and worried, all myoid classmates, so amazingly different, each of them. My Avian Pride dies right then. A tear drops onto my T-shirt. Human! Birds can't cry. But then I see the tear roll down my arm, and I see the downy underfeathers sprouting now as my arm turns wing. Too late. Too late. I'm speechless, and I feel only love. Love. Oh, I wish I could communicate with the species!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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